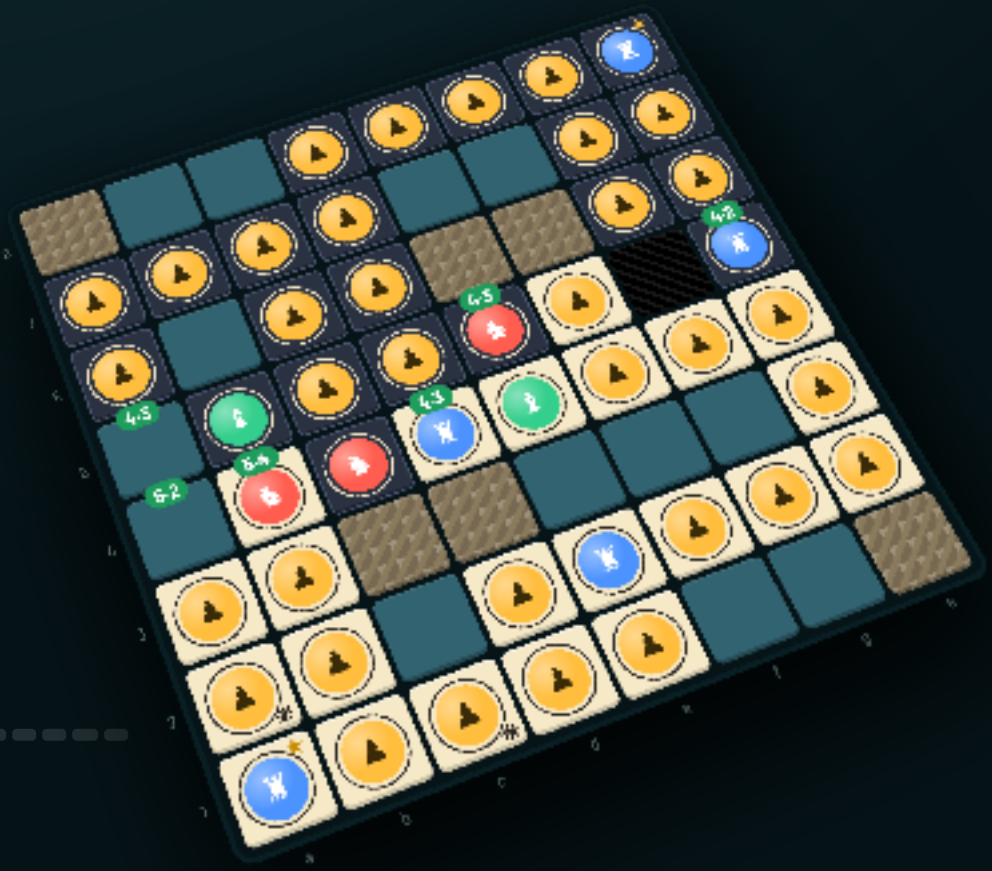
HOLDAGE

Hidden orders. Hold the board.

PLAYER'S GUIDE

Units, combat, every mechanic, buildings, the economy, the four game modes, Warlords for eight realms, puzzles, tournaments, rating — and how to win, with worked examples.



CLASSIC · NORMAL BOT VS NORMAL BOT

ROUND 11 / 20

22 vs 22

CELLS AFTER ROUND 11

VERSION 7.6.1

MPE SOFTWARE

CONTENTS

01	The game in one minute	3
02	The board and your first round	4
03	Giving orders	5
04	The units	6
05	Combat	7
06	Clashes, garrisons and burned cells	9
07	Mechanics: movement	10
08	Mechanics: force	11
09	Mechanics: special orders	12
10	Supply lines	13
11	Buildings	14
12	Reinforcements and economy	15
13	How to win	16
14	The home screen	17
15	Reading the game screen	18
16	Game modes	19
17	Daily, named and shared boards	22
18	Tactical puzzles	23
19	Tournaments	24
20	Playing online	26
21	Notifications	27
22	Rating and rating proof	28
23	Warlords: eight realms	29
24	Warlords: truces and betrayal	31
25	Warlords online and bots	32
26	Strategy guide	34
27	Quick reference	38
28	Glossary	39

HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

Every diagram uses the game's own colours: **ivory cells are yours**, **dark cells are the rival's**, **teal** cells are free, **brown** cells are rock. Orders you plan have a dashed amber frame and a number; the rival's revealed orders have a coral frame. The unit you send sits in the corner of the cell; the garrison stays in the middle. Pills show attack·defense: 5·3 wins, 3·3 falls short. Every position and number was computed by the game engine itself.

THE GAME IN ONE MINUTE

HoldAge is a duel on an 8 × 8 board. Each round both players give up to three orders **in secret and at the same time**. Nobody can react to what the other does: you have to read your rival, not just the board.

1
PLAN
Tap cells to give up to 3 orders: place units, attack, shoot, build, set an ambush.

2
SEAL
Confirm. Your orders are locked with a hash; the rival does the same. Online you have 60 seconds.

3
REVEAL
Both sets are revealed and resolved together: clashes, attacks, shots, buildings, supply.

4
GROW
Everyone receives reinforcements based on territory and buildings. Next round.

FOUR WAYS TO WIN

★
CAPITAL
Take the rival capital.

■
DOMINATION
Hold 65% of the playable cells.

↑
LEAD
From round 10, end a round 10 cells ahead.

Σ
POINTS
After round 20: 1 point per cell + 1 per building.

> **THE ONE IDEA TO REMEMBER**
> Everything you own must stay connected to your capital through your own cells. Cut the rival at their narrowest point and everything behind the cut is lost at the end of the round.

INSIDE A ROUND: WHAT RESOLVES FIRST

1 **AMBUSHES** Units that step on one are lost.

2 **PLACEMENTS** Conquests, attacks and clashes, cell by cell.

3 **SHOTS** Against what is left on the target.

4 **BUILDINGS** Built if the cell is still yours; else refunded.

5 **LOOT** A soldier for whoever captured rival ground.

6 **SUPPLY** Cells cut off from their capital are lost.

7 **VICTORY** Capital, hill, domination, lead, then the last round.

8 **INCOME** Reinforcements for both, then the next round.

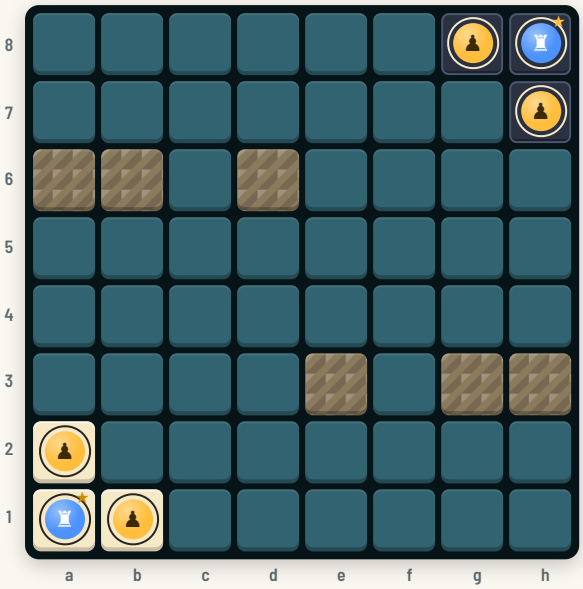
WHERE TO PLAY

AGAINST THE BOT
Easy (1000) or Normal (1550). Offline, saved after every round: the home screen replays your game and **HOLD** continues it.

ONLINE
Create a room, send the 5-letter code, play device to device with no game server.

CHALLENGES
Daily board, named boards, tactical puzzles and tournaments.

THE BOARD AND YOUR FIRST ROUND



A real starting board. Your capital ★ is always bottom-left (a1), the rival's top-right (h8). Each starts with infantry on the capital and two pawns beside it. Six rocks, placed in mirrored pairs, can never be entered.

FACTS ABOUT THE BOARD

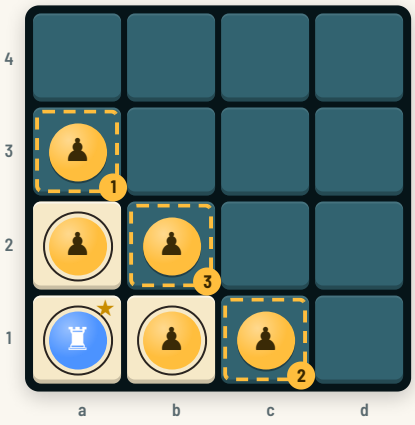
- **58** playable cells (64 minus the rocks).
- Domination needs **38** of them (65%).
- The board is symmetric: both players have exactly the same chances.
- Each player sees their own capital bottom-left.

YOUR STARTING RESERVE

4	2	2	2
Pawn	Infantry	Cavalry	Archers

You can hold at most 6 of each type in reserve.

A GOOD FIRST ROUND



Three pawns: two cells straight out of the corner and the diagonal between them. Cheap, compact, and it fills the gap the rival could cut later.

1. **Expand with pawns first.** Free cells have no defender: a pawn takes them as well as a soldier, and pawns are your cheapest piece (you receive at least 3 every round).
2. **Keep soldiers for fights.** Infantry, cavalry and archers decide clashes; do not spend them on empty cells early.
3. **Grow wide, not long.** A blob is hard to cut; a long line is easy prey.

> **FIRST GAME?**
> The tutorial opens the first time you play. You can reopen the rules at any time from the **?** button at the top of the home screen or from the game menu.

GIVING ORDERS

You have **3 orders per round** (4 with Reaction, see page 12). Each order uses one cell; a cell takes one order. Orders cost units from your reserve.

Place on a free cell
Conquers it. Any unit works; a pawn is enough.

Place on a rival cell
An attack: it wins if your attack beats the defense (page 7).

Place on your own cell
Changes the garrison. The old unit goes back to your reserve.

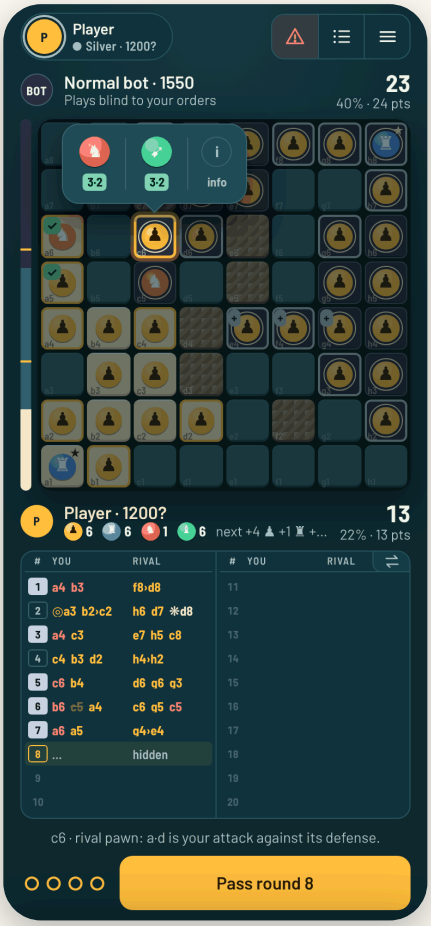
Shoot (archers)
Removes a rival piece two cells away in a straight line, without occupying it.

Ambush (1 pawn)
A hidden trap on a free cell next to you, for 5 rounds.

Build (pawns)
Farm, barracks or wall on your cell; bridge over a black cell.

REACH

- Units reach cells **next to your territory** (up, down, left, right).
- **Cavalry reaches two cells** away.
- With a **march**, an order continues in a straight line from another order on a free cell (page 10).



On the phone: cells you can play are lit (amber frame for free cells, coral for rival cells, with your best a·d). Tap one and a bubble lists only the legal orders, each with its attack·defense or cost — a shot shows the archers with ➹. Tap outside to close it. The dots next to the button count your orders; the button reads *Confirm round N* or *Pass*.

OUT OF REACH?

Tap a dimmed cell and the hint explains why (too far, no unit left that reaches it, a black cell…). Tap it again to see its numbers. And if an order would leave a cell with no path to your land, the bubble warns you: that cell is lost at the end of the round.

THREE KEY IDEAS ON THIS PAGE

1. **3 orders a round**, one per cell, each paid with a unit from your reserve.
2. **The cell decides the order:** free cell = conquest, rival cell = attack, your cell = garrison change.
3. **You reach only cells next to your land** — cavalry two away, marches further.

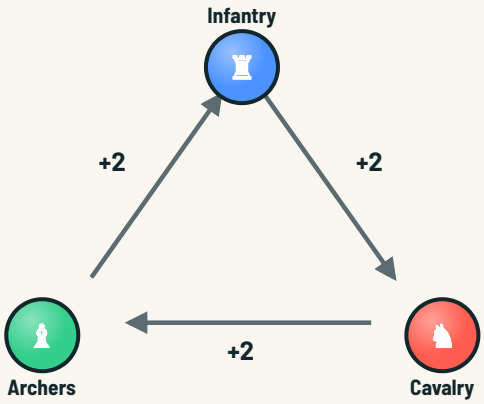
THE UNITS

Pawn
Strength 1

VERB	Marches
BONUS	Pays for buildings and ambushes.
BEST FOR	Expanding, filling gaps, marches, economy.

Infantry
Strength 2

VERB	Pushes
BEATS	Cavalry
BONUS	+1 when defending. Push: +1 per own cell in a row behind the attack, from the second (max +2).
BEST FOR	Holding key cells, the capital, heavy frontal attacks.



The triangle. Each military unit beats the next one: the **advantage adds +2**, in attack and in defense. It never wins on its own: numbers decide.

Cavalry
Strength 2

VERB	Charges
BEATS	Archers
BONUS	Reaches 2 cells. Charge: +1 with a run-up (an own cell two steps away, the cell between free).
BEST FOR	Raids behind the front, cutting supply lines.

Archers
Strength 2

VERB	Shoot
BEATS	Infantry
BONUS	+1 when attacking. Shot: removes a piece 2 cells away in a straight line.
BEST FOR	Breaking defended cells, removing a garrison before an attack.

READING THE TRIANGLE

Infantry beats cavalry, cavalry beats archers, archers beat infantry. Pawns are outside the triangle: strength 1, no advantage either way.

SOLDIERS ARRIVE BY ROTATION

Your capital produces one soldier every round, rotating infantry → cavalry → archers. Plan your attacks around what you will have next round.

COMBAT

An attack takes a rival cell only if **attack > defense**. Ties go to the defender. Both numbers are a sum of small bonuses, all shown in the game when you tap an order.

ATTACK

1 or 2	Strength of the unit (pawn 1, soldiers 2).
+2	Advantage: your unit beats the defender's in the triangle.
+1	Strike: archers attacking.
+1...+2	Flank: your cells touching the target, beyond the first.
+1	Charge: cavalry with a run-up.
+1...+2	Push: infantry with a row of your cells behind.
+1...+2	Lance: a march that ends in an attack out of normal reach, +1 per link.

DEFENSE

1 or 2	Strength of the garrison.
+2	Advantage: the garrison beats the attacker in the triangle.
+1	Hold: infantry defending.
+2	A wall on the cell.
+2	The capital.
+1...+2	Support: own neighbours of the cell, beyond the first.
+1	Phalanx: the cell is in a line of 3 or more with at most two own neighbours (page 11).

EXAMPLE 1 · CAVALRY AGAINST ARCHERS



Your cavalry attacks the archers on d3. Three of your cells touch d3.

Cavalry	6	=	2 base + 2 advantage + 2 flank
Archers	2	=	2 base

6 > 2 · THE ATTACK WINS

Cavalry beats archers (+2) and three of your cells surround d3, which gives the maximum flank (+2). Even archers would win here: 5 vs 2.

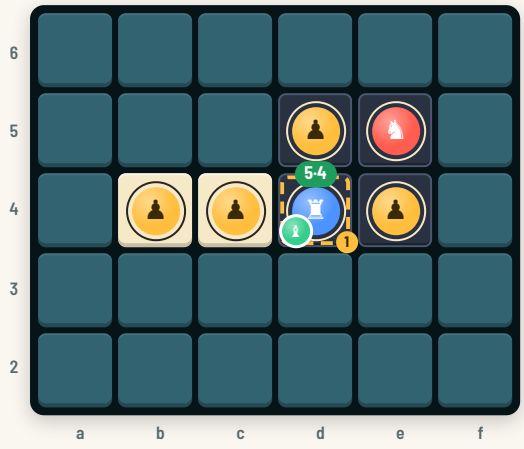
In the diagrams, the unit you send sits in the corner of the cell it attacks; the garrison stays in the middle.

THREE KEY IDEAS ON THIS PAGE

1. **Attack must beat defense.** Ties go to the defender: 4 vs 4 fails.
2. **Check the triangle first.** The advantage (+2) works both ways: a garrison that beats your unit gets it too.
3. **Shape adds up.** Flank, support and the other shape bonuses count the board as it was at the start of the round.

COMBAT: CHOOSING THE RIGHT UNIT

EXAMPLE 2 · ONE TARGET, THREE ATTACKERS



Rival infantry on d4, supported by a neighbour. Which unit do you send?

Archers · wins

Attack	5	=	2 base + 2 advantage + 1 strike
Defense	4	=	2 base + 1 hold + 1 support

5 > 4 · THE ATTACK WINS

Infantry · falls short

Attack	3	=	2 base + 1 push
Defense	4	=	2 base + 1 hold + 1 support

3 ≤ 4 · THE DEFENDER HOLDS

Cavalry · crushed

Attack	2	=	2 base
Defense	6	=	2 base + 2 advantage + 1 hold + 1 support

2 ≤ 6 · THE DEFENDER HOLDS

THE LESSON

Against a garrison, look at its unit first and send the one that beats it. The same attack can be a sure win or a disaster: here 5·4 with archers, 2·6 with cavalry.

SIMULTANEOUS ORDERS CHANGE EVERYTHING

The numbers above assume the rival leaves d4 as it is. But they move at the same time as you: if they **change the garrison** of d4 to cavalry in the same round, your archers now face a unit that beats them. The defense always uses the garrison *after* the rival's order on that cell.

ATTACK WHERE THEY CANNOT ANSWER

A cell the rival also needs to defend elsewhere, or a cell whose garrison they cannot change (no matching unit in reserve), is a safer target.

USE THE FORECAST

Every planned attack shows its a·d on the board. Turn on ⚠ *Threats* to see which of your cells can fall this round if the rival guesses right.

CLASHES, GARRISONS AND BURNED CELLS

When both players send a unit to the same cell in the same round, the cell decides between them.



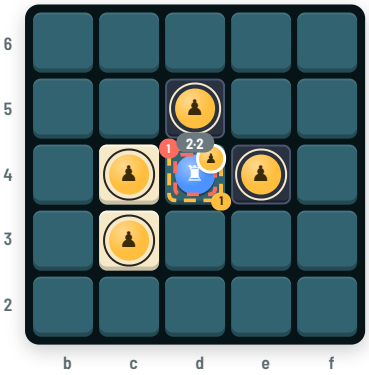
The same round, three free cells, after resolution. You (ivory) sent cavalry to d3, infantry to d5 and a pawn to d7; the rival sent archers, cavalry and a pawn.

d3	vs	Both are attackers: 4 vs 3 (archers keep their +1 strike). The stronger takes the cell.
d5	vs	Infantry beats cavalry: 4 vs 2.
d7	vs	**The same unit on a free cell: it burns.** It becomes a black cell that nobody can hold, until a bridge reclaims it.
=	equal	Different units with equal attack: they bounce off. The cell stays free and both units are spent.

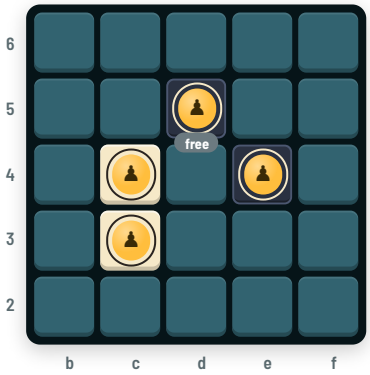
ON AN OCCUPIED CELL

- If the owner also sends a unit there, it becomes the new garrison and defends. The old garrison returns to their reserve.
- If both send **the same unit** to an occupied cell, the attack fails: the owner keeps the cell, with that unit as the new garrison.
- On a capital, the same unit means the owner keeps it.

= EXAMPLE · A BOUNCE



Planned: your infantry and a rival pawn, both to the free d4.



After: d4 is still free; both units are spent.

Your infantry attacks with 2. The rival's pawn has only strength 1, but two rival cells touch d4 (e4, d5): flank +1, so 2 as well. **2 vs 2, different units: they bounce.** Infantry against cavalry can never bounce on its own — infantry beats cavalry and attacks with 4 against 2.

MIND GAMES

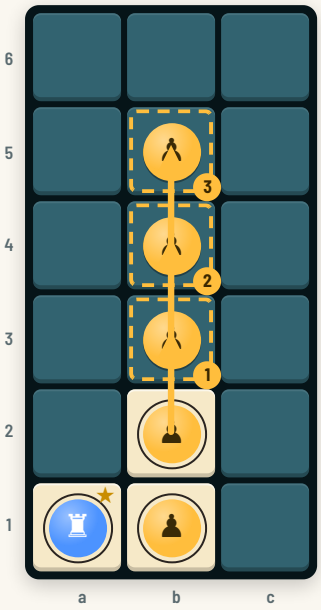
Burned cells are the price of guessing the same thing. Sending a pawn to a contested free cell is cheap, but if the rival thinks the same, the cell is gone for both. Sending a soldier wins the clash against a pawn.

AMBUSHES COME FIRST

A unit that steps on an ambush is lost before any clash is resolved (page 12).

MECHANICS: MOVEMENT

MARCH

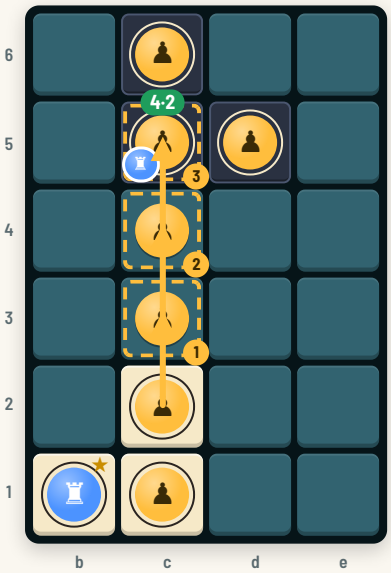


Three pawns march from b2 to b5 in one round.

An order may continue **in a straight line** from another order on a free cell. The first link must touch your territory; each next one extends the line in the same direction.

- Any unit can be a link; pawns are the cheap choice.
- Order matters: give the orders in path order (1, 2, 3).
- Skipping a link is illegal: b3 then b5 alone is refused.
- **A march never turns:** the cell behind each link must be yours or another link. A link on a3 that grew from a2 goes on to a4, never to b3.
- **Risk:** if one link fails (a clash, a burned cell, an ambush), everything after it is cut off from supply.

LANCE



Two pawn links, then infantry hits c5.

A march can **end in an attack** on a rival cell. The tip gains +1 per link travelled, up to +2.

Lance	4	=	2 base	+ 2 lance
Defense	2	=	1 base	+ 1 support

4 > 2 · THE ATTACK WINS

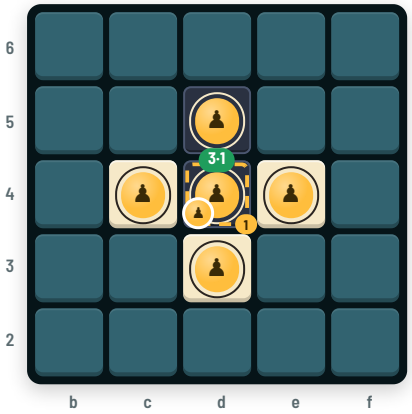
c5 is out of normal reach: only a march gets there, and the two links turn the infantry's 2 into 4. Even next to your land a plain attack would only be 2 vs 2 — a tie, and ties go to the defender.

ONLY OUT OF REACH

The lance bonus counts only when the target is beyond your normal reach. A march that ends next to your own territory attacks at normal strength.

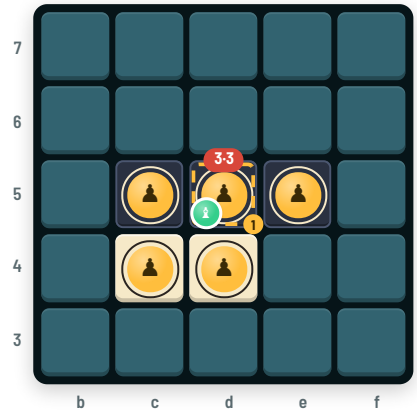
MECHANICS: FORCE

FLANK



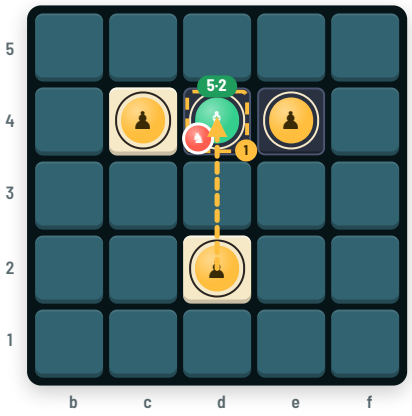
Each of your cells touching the target beyond the first adds +1 (max +2). Three of yours around d4: a pawn takes a pawn 3 vs 1.

PHALANX AND SUPPORT



d5 is in a line of three with only two own neighbours: a phalanx (+1), plus support (+1 per own neighbour beyond the first, max +2). The archers' 3 only ties 3: the defender holds.

CHARGE



Cavalry gets +1 when an own cell sits two steps away in a line with a free cell between (d2 → d3 → d4). Here: 5 vs 2, with the advantage over archers.

PUSH



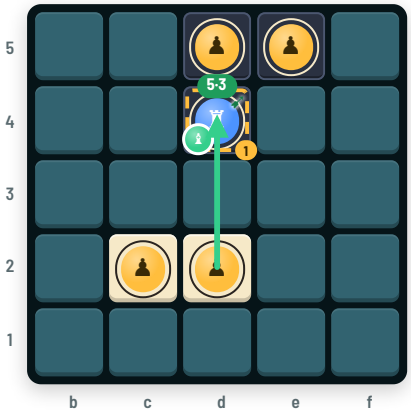
Infantry gets +1 per own cell in a row behind the attack, from the second (max +2). Three in a column (d3, d2, d1): +2, plus the advantage over cavalry: 6 vs 2.

SHAPE IS STRENGTH

Flank, support, push and charge all reward **where your cells are**, not how many units you have. Before attacking, ask: how many of my cells touch the target? Is there a row behind it? A run-up?

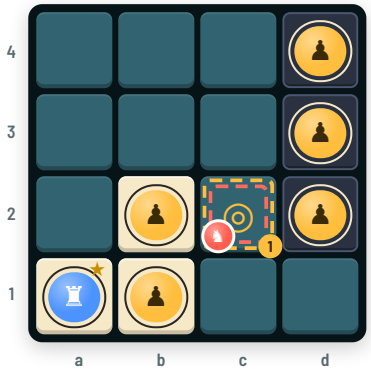
MECHANICS: SPECIAL ORDERS

SHOT



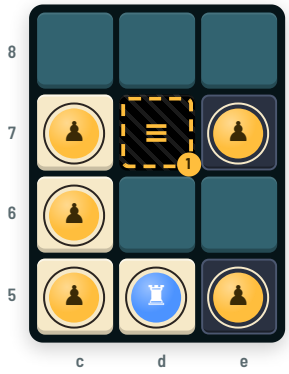
Archers remove a rival piece **two cells away in a straight line** from one of your cells, without occupying it (the cell becomes free). Shot power: 2 + strike 1 + advantage if it applies. Here 5 vs 3: hit. One more rival neighbour (c4 or e4) adds support and the defense becomes 4: still a hit. A full line c4–d4–e4 (phalanx and support) or three neighbours raise it to 5, and the shot misses. The capital cannot be shot; a rock in between blocks it.

AMBUSH



Costs 1 pawn. A hidden trap on a free cell next to your territory, for 5 rounds. Only you see it (◎). If the rival places a unit there — here their cavalry — that unit is lost before anything else resolves. One ambush at a time. It is never revealed unless it springs.

BRIDGE



For 2 pawns, a black cell next to your territory becomes yours, with a pawn. Bridges do not score building points. If both players bridge the same cell in the same round, neither gets it and the pawns are refunded.

REACTION



If you trail by **6 cells or more** at the start of a round, you get a **fourth order** that round. The game tells you in the hint, and a fourth dot appears next to the button.

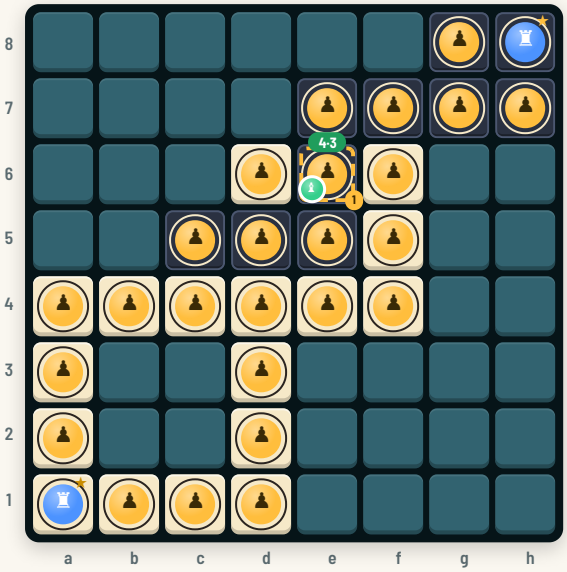
Use it to strike back, not to expand: a cut or a capture swings both players' counts at once.

LOOT

Capturing at least one rival cell in a round gives you one random soldier as loot.

SUPPLY LINES

At the end of every round, every cell that is not connected to its owner's capital through that owner's cells (up, down, left, right) is **lost**: it becomes free, with its unit and building.



Before: the rival's line runs from h8 down to c5. Its neck is e6. Your archers attack it.



After: e6 falls (4 vs 3) and c5, d5, e5 lose their link to the capital. One capture, 4 cells gone from the rival.

ATTACK NECKS, DEFEND NECKS

The most valuable cell on the board is usually a rival cell whose capture disconnects many others. The game's ⚠ *Threats* view marks the cells of yours that could fall this round: look at the ones that connect large areas.

MARCHES AND SUPPLY

A march that loses one link loses everything after it at the end of the round. Long marches into contested ground are a gamble.

BUILDINGS

Buildings are paid with pawns and placed on your own cells (never the capital), one per cell. Each finished building (not bridges) adds 1 point to the round-20 score. If the cell changes hands in the same round, the pawns are refunded.

✳ FARM
2 PAWNS

+1 pawn every round.

Example: Built on round 3, it has paid for itself by round 5 and keeps giving: 17 pawns by the end (15 more than it cost).

When: Early, on a safe inner cell far from the front.

⚑ BARRACKS
3 PAWNS

+1 unit of the type garrisoning the cell, every round.

Example: Barracks under cavalry: +1 cavalry per round. Change the garrison to change the production.

When: When you know which soldier you need most; protect it, it is a prime target.

▦ WALL
3 PAWNS

+2 defense for the cell.

Example: A walled pawn holds against cavalry: 2 vs 3.

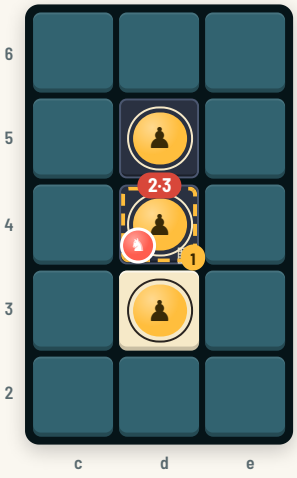
When: On necks and border cells near your capital.

≡ BRIDGE
2 PAWNS

Turns an adjacent black cell into yours, with a pawn.

Example: Two burned cells split your land: a bridge reconnects it and opens a new path.

When: To reconnect, or to open a shortcut toward the rival.



A walled rival pawn repels your cavalry.

PAYBACK

	COST	RETURNS	PAYS BACK
✳ Farm	2 ♟	1 ♟ / round	2 rounds
⚑ Barracks	3 ♟	1 soldier / round	1–2 rounds (soldiers are worth more)
▦ Wall	3 ♟	+2 defense	the first attack it stops

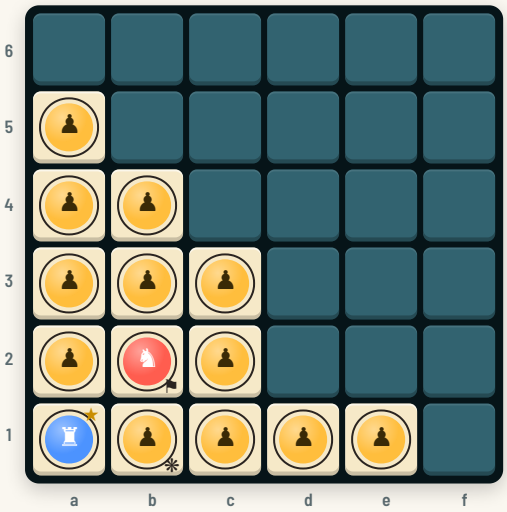
Every building is also worth 1 point at round 20: in a close game, two late farms can decide the winner.

REINFORCEMENTS AND ECONOMY

After every round, if the game goes on, both players receive reinforcements. More land means more units.

SOURCE	YOU RECEIVE
Territory	1 pawn per 3 cells (at least 3)
Territory	1 soldier per 5 cells, continuing the rotation infantry → cavalry → archers
Capital	1 soldier of the round's type (the same rotation)
❋ / ⚑	1 pawn per farm; 1 unit per barracks (its garrison type)
Loot	1 random soldier when you captured rival ground
Cap	At most 6 of each type in reserve: the rest is lost

WORKED EXAMPLE



Round 6: 14 cells, a farm on b1 and barracks under cavalry on b2.

Pawns	14 cells ÷ 3 = 4, + 1 farm	5
Capital	round 6 produces archers	1
Territory	14 ÷ 5 = 2 soldiers, next in the rotation	1 1
Barracks	garrisoned by cavalry	1
Total next round		**5 1 2 1**

WATCH THE NEXT ROUND

Your player row shows your reserve and, after "next", exactly what you will receive. Plan attacks for the units you are about to get.

ECONOMY RULE OF THUMB

Every 3 cells is a pawn and every 5 cells a soldier, every round. Taking 5 cells early is worth more than a building — but a farm built by round 4 is almost always worth it.

HOW TO WIN

★ CAPITAL

Take the rival capital and you win at once. If both capitals fall in the same round, points decide.

The capital defends with +2 and starts with infantry: even archers with the advantage only reach 5 vs 6 here, and cavalry 2 vs 8. Take its neighbours first: they stop supporting it, and every own cell around it adds flank (page 35).

■ DOMINATION

Hold 65% of the playable cells at the end of a round: 38 of 58 on a board with six rocks. Black cells do not count as playable.

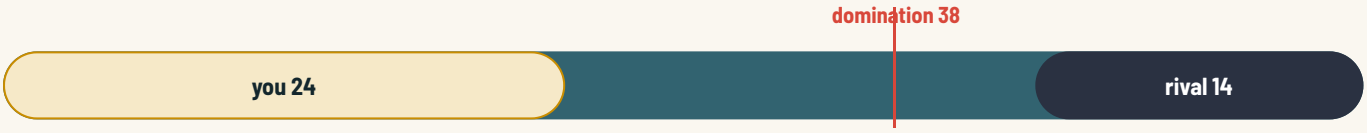
↑ LEAD

From round 10, end a round with 10 more cells than the rival. The territory bar beside the board shows the gap.

Σ POINTS

After round 20: 1 point per cell + 1 per finished building (bridges excluded). Ties: more cells, then more soldiers on the board.

THE TERRITORY BAR



24 – 14 = 10: from round 10 this lead wins the game. Domination needs 38 of 58 cells.

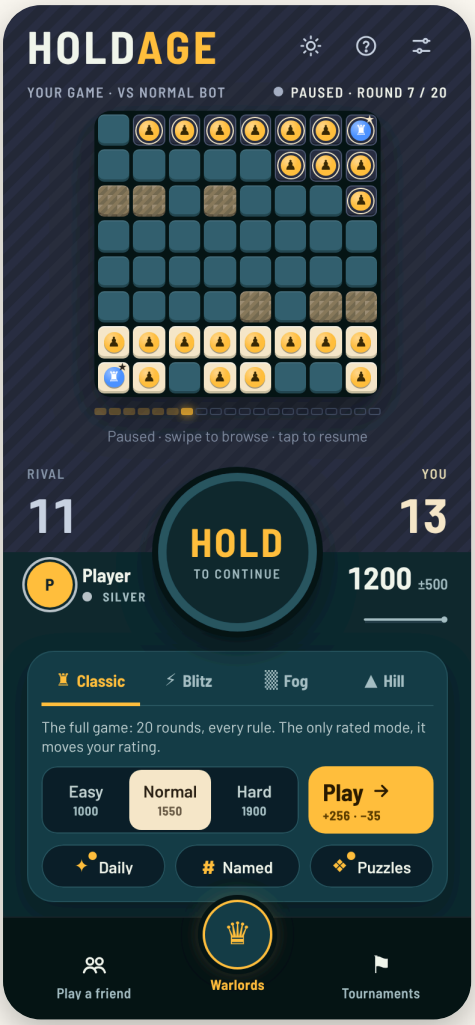
RESIGNING AND LEAVING

- Resigning ends the game as a loss.
- Against the bot, starting a new game over one in progress counts the old one as a loss.
- Online, a rival who stays offline for 90 seconds lets you claim the win. Leaving a room unfinished for two hours counts as a loss.

WHICH VICTORY TO AIM FOR

Most games end on points or on the lead victory. Capital wins come from cuts that leave the capital isolated and thin; domination from a long run of good rounds. Track the bar: at 8 cells ahead from round 9, one good round can end the game.

THE HOME SCREEN



The home screen is your game, live. The rival's half — the fog — sits on top with both cell counts; below it, in the theme you chose (dark or light), your profile, your rating and one play card. Between them, the **HOLD** button.

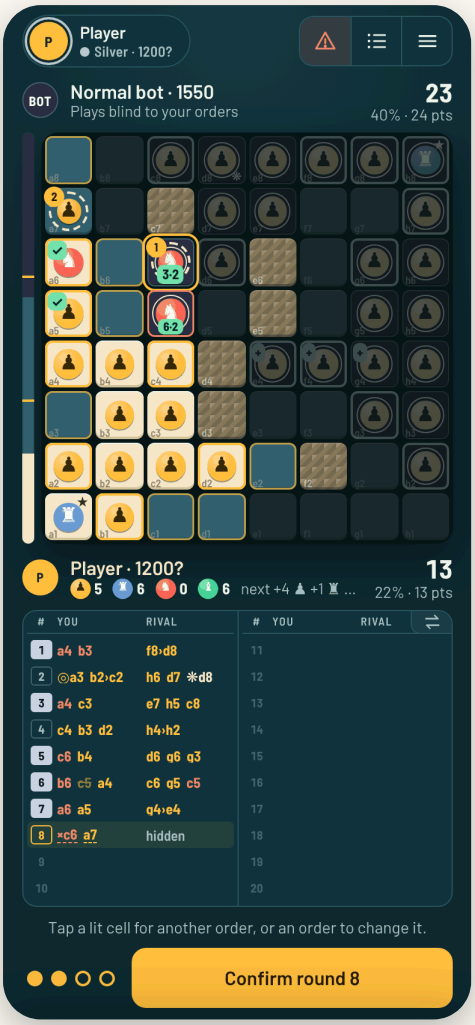
1. **Title and tools** — the sun (or moon) switches between the dark and the light theme, remembered on this device; **?** opens the rules; the sliders open the settings, with **notifications** (page 27) and the version.
2. **Replay** — your saved game plays in a loop, round by round, with its label (*Your game · vs Normal bot*) and the round (*Round 7 / 20*). With no game in progress, a demo between two bots plays instead.
3. **Tap to pause, swipe to browse.** Tap the board to stop on a round; swipe left or right to step through the rounds. The strip below the board marks where you are. The replay resumes on its own after a few seconds.
4. **Cell counts** — the rival's on the left, yours on the right, for the round shown.
5. **HOLD** — press and hold until the ring fills: *to continue* your game, or *to play* a new one when there is none. A quick tap only gives a nudge, so you never start by accident.
6. **Profile and rating** — left of the ring, your avatar, name and tier; right of it, your rating with its ± range (the same figure as on your profile; wide while the rating is provisional), its change over your last rated games and a small curve. Tap either for the profile card: rating, tier progress, record by rival, *Export proof* and *Full profile*.
7. **Mode tabs** — Classic, Blitz, Fog and Hill. Tap one to choose it: the line underneath explains it. Only Classic is rated.
8. **Bot · Play** — pick Easy, Normal or Hard and press **Play** for a new game against the bot (a game in progress counts as a loss). In Classic, Play shows what is at stake: the rating you would gain by winning and lose by losing.
9. **Daily · Named · Puzzles** — today's board, a named board and the puzzles (each wears a gold dot while something new waits).
10. **The dock** — *Play a friend* to create or join an online room, **Warlords** in the round button in the middle (page 29; a gold dot when it is your turn in a room) and *Tournaments* (a red dot means new results).

The home always fits one screen, like an app: on short phones the hint, the mode explanation, then the bot ratings and your name step aside; on tablets in landscape and on computers it opens in two columns.

BANNERS

Rejoin online game appears for two hours after an online game is interrupted; *Continue practice* appears when a practice game (daily, named, shared, tournament) is in progress. HOLD continues your rated game first.

READING THE GAME SCREEN



1. **Header** — your profile plate; in the middle, the mode, puzzle or tournament board; on the right ⚠ *Threats*, the round log and the menu.
2. **Rival row** — name and rating, status (planning, ready ✓, offline), cells, share and points.
3. **Territory bar** — yours rises from the bottom, the rival's drops from the top; ticks at 35% and 65%.
4. **Board** — lit cells are in reach; striped cells (with ⚠ on) can fall this round; ✓ / × marks show last round's results.
5. **Your row** — your reserve, counting down as you plan, and what you will receive next round.
6. **Score sheet** — every round in chess-like notation, coloured by unit. Tap a round to replay it; ⇄ switches to the 20-round strip.
7. **Confirm** — the dots count your orders; tap twice to pass with none.

NOTATION

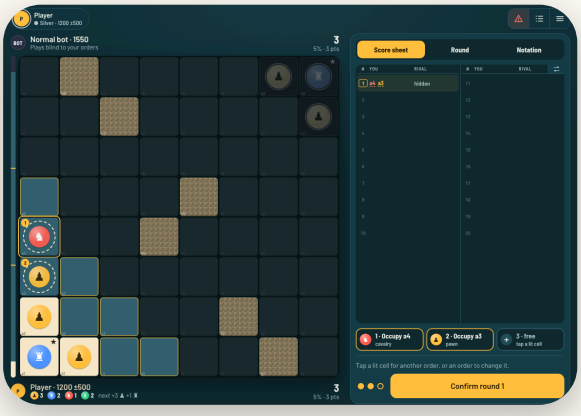
×	attack	›	march link
=	garrison change	#	burned cell
➶	shot	◎	ambush
~~a4~~	failed	?×2	hidden by fog

REPLAY ANY ROUND

In replay, every cell played that round splits in two: the rival's move on top, yours below. The winner gets an amber (you) or silver (rival) frame, and the pill shows attack·defense.

HELD SIDEWAYS

On a tablet turned sideways, a computer or a phone on its side, the board stays on one side and a panel opens on the other: **Score sheet** (⇄ still switches to the strip), **Round** (the report of the last or the replayed round, also from the log button) and **Notation**; under them your orders as chips (tap one to change it) and Confirm. Warlords does the same: the map on one side; the realms, your reserve and **History · Realms · Orders** on the other.



GAME MODES

Pick the mode with the four tabs of the play card on the home screen: tap one and the line below explains it. It applies to games against the bot, named boards and the rooms you host (the guest plays the host's mode). **Only Classic is rated**; the other modes are casual and have their own record. Every mode can be played against the Easy, Normal or Hard bot. Warlords, for up to eight realms, has its own screens and rating (page 29).

	ROUNDS	START RESERVE	LEAD VICTORY	ONLINE TIMER	SPECIAL
♜ **Classic**	20	4·2·2·2	from 10, +10	60 s	Rated
⚡ **Blitz**	12	6·3·3·3	from 6, +8	30 s	—
▒ **Fog of war**	20	4·2·2·2	from 10, +10	60 s	Hidden pieces
▲ **King of the hill**	20	4·2·2·2	from 10, +10	60 s	Hill victory

Start reserve: pawns · infantry · cavalry · archers.

⚡ BLITZ

A short, sharp game: 12 rounds, a bigger reserve from the start, and the lead victory from round 6 with 8 cells. Online, 30 seconds per round.

- Spend soldiers early: there is no time to save them.
- Farms rarely pay back in 12 rounds; walls on your necks do.
- One good cut at round 6–8 often ends the game.

WHICH MODE FOR WHAT

♜ CLASSIC

Ranked games, the full strategic arc: economy, shape, timing.

⚡ BLITZ

A game in five minutes; sharp tactics, little economy.

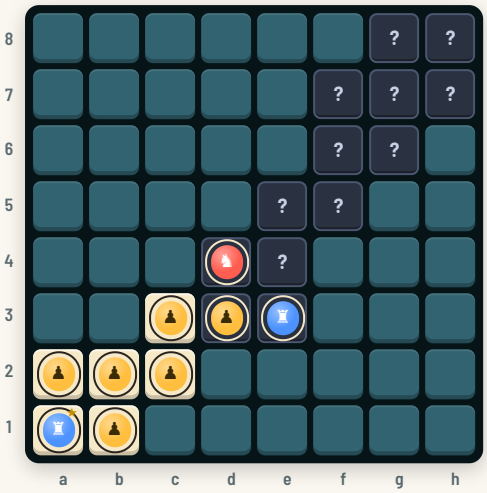
▒ FOG OF WAR

Bluff and reading: scouting matters, surprise attacks work.

▲ KING OF THE HILL

A clear objective in the middle: great for teaching tempo.

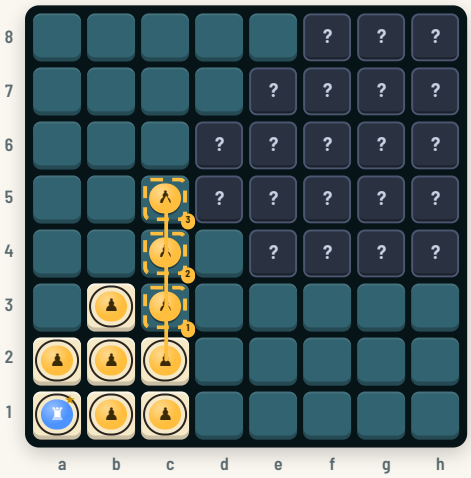
GAME MODES: FOG OF WAR



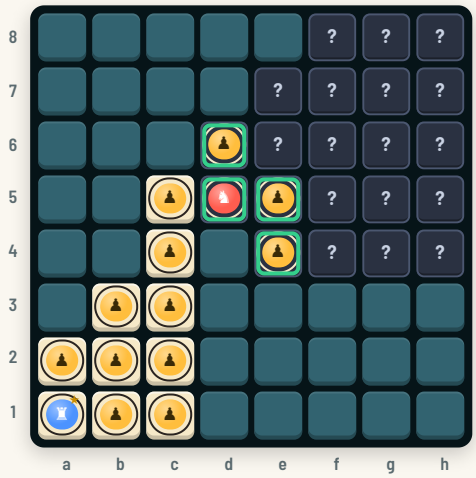
You see the rival's territory, but not what holds cells more than 2 steps from your land.

- Rival cells within 2 steps of yours show their units and buildings; the rest show **?**.
- Rival orders out of sight stay hidden in the reveal, the score sheet (**?×2**) and the replay.
- Attacks on hidden cells show **?** instead of a·d: you guess the garrison.
- The bot plays by the same fog. The fog lifts when the game ends.

EXAMPLE · SCOUTING WITH A MARCH



Round N: three pawns march c3 → c5. The rival land beyond is ?.



Round N+1: sight now reaches 2 cells past c5 — d6, d5, e5, e4 are revealed (green).

Sight comes only from **cells you own** at the start of a round: every cell sees 2 steps around it. Units do not walk back, so "scouting" means owning a cell closer to the rival. Pawns are the cheap way: a three-pawn march costs 3 pawns and here uncovers 4 rival cells, including the cavalry on d5.

The march must stay connected to your land, or its cells are lost at the end of the round — and their sight with them.

CAVALRY RAIDS

Cavalry reaches 2 cells, so it can hit a rival cell you can see but not touch. Alone, the raided cell is not linked to your land: it is cut off at the end of the round and becomes free. You lose the cavalry, the rival loses the cell — and anything that hung on it. Add a pawn on the cell between (a march) and you keep it, and its sight.

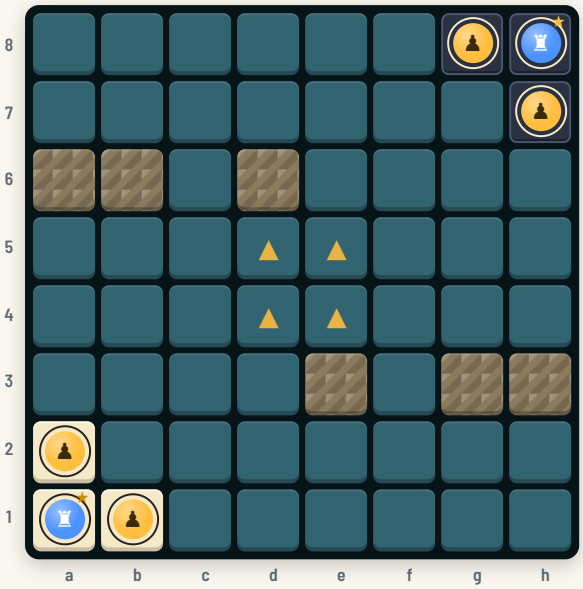
ARCHERS DO NOT SCOUT

A shot reaches exactly 2 cells — the same as your sight — so archers only hit what you can already see. In the fog they are a sure tool against a garrison you can read, not a way to look further. Lances that end on a hidden cell show **?**: you attack blind.

TIP

Your build-up is hidden too: the rival only sees your cells within 2 steps of theirs. Gather soldiers out of their sight, then strike — cuts and raids are stronger in the fog, counted attacks weaker.

GAME MODES: KING OF THE HILL



The hill: the four centre cells (d4, e4, d5, e5), marked ▲. They are never rock.

Hold **3 of the 4 hill cells** at the end of **3 rounds in a row** and you win. Losing the hold resets your count. Capital, domination, lead and points still win as usual.

- Your row and the rival's show the count: ▲ **2/3** means two rounds held.
- The centre is far from both capitals: a race there leaves your flanks open.
- The hill cells touch each other: holding three or four of them gives each one support (+1), and infantry adds hold (+1).
- At ▲ 2/3 the rival must hit the hill this round — prepare the counter.

TEMPO

In 80 test games between Normal bots, three in four (60) ended on the hill, usually around round 8 or 9. March pawns toward the centre early, then bring infantry to hold it.

DAILY, NAMED AND SHARED BOARDS

Every board comes from a seed. A seed made from a date or a name gives the same board to everyone, with no server. These boards can be studied in advance, so they are **practice**: they never change your rating.

DAILY CHALLENGE

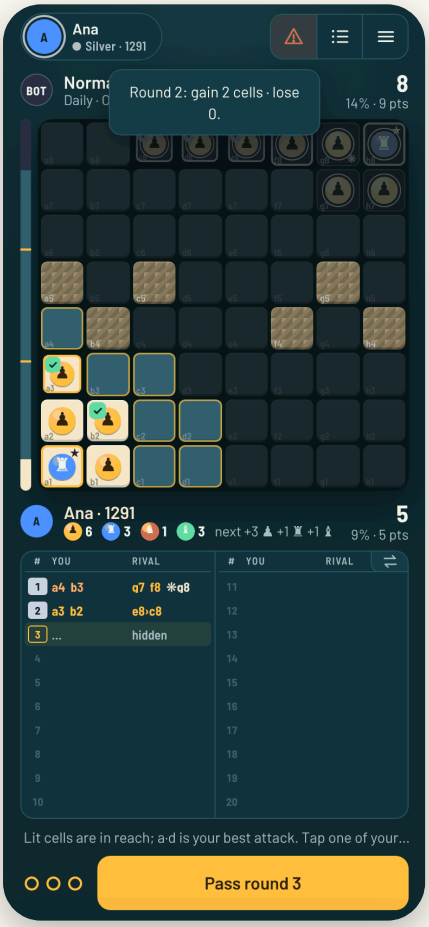
One board for everyone each day (it changes at 00:00 UTC), against the Normal bot, **one attempt**. On the home screen, *Daily* wears a gold dot until you play today's board. At the end, *Share result* sends a spoiler-free summary: one square per round (🟩 you won it, 🟥 the rival did, ⬜ even).

NAMED BOARDS

Type any name and get a board: "Castle", "castle" and " CASTLE " are the same one. Send the name or the *Share board* link to a friend and compare how you did on the very same board, in the mode you selected.

SHARED GAMES

Share game at the end of a game (or from any recent game in your profile) makes a link with the whole game. Whoever opens it watches every round on the board, then can *Play this board* against the bot.



USING THEM TO IMPROVE

1. Play the daily, then open a friend's shared game of the same day: compare openings round by round.
2. Lost a game? Share it to yourself, replay it, and use *Play this board* to try a different plan on the same rocks.
3. Named boards make house rules easy: "this week everyone plays *Iron Gate* on Normal".

PRACTICE SLOT

Practice games have their own save slot: they never replace your rated game in progress. Continue one from the *Continue practice* banner on the home screen (or with HOLD when no rated game is in progress).

TACTICAL PUZZLES

Sixty real positions from games between bots, in three levels. **The rival's orders are revealed** (coral frames): find your orders for the round. The goal is either to **win the game this round** or to reach a **swing** — the cells you gain plus the cells the rival loses — as large as the best one a search found.

EXAMPLE · PUZZLE 3: SWING 7 CELLS



The position, with the rival's three orders in coral. You play ivory.



The solution in amber: Cavalry b3, Infantry e6, Pawn d5 — with the engine's results.

Read the coral orders: the rival marches two pawns down the b-file (b5, b4) and finishes with an archers' lance on your pawn at b3. **The solution:** change b3's garrison to cavalry — it beats archers, and the lance now fails 5 vs 6. Infantry takes e6 (4 vs 3), the neck of the rival's left side: a6, b6, c6, d6 and the two cells the rival just took are cut off. A pawn takes the free d5. Swing 7: you gain 2, the rival loses 5.

★★★

Solved on the first try. Second try ★★, later ★.

HINT

Lights one cell of the best plan. Caps the solve at ★★.

SOLUTION

Plans it for you to watch it play out. Worth ★.

HOW TO SOLVE

1. Read the coral orders: where will the rival be weaker after them? 2. Look for necks (supply cuts are worth many cells). 3. Check clashes: a stronger unit on the cell the rival is entering wins it. 4. Any plan that reaches the target solves the puzzle — beating it is fine too. A puzzle of the day, the same for everyone, sits on top of the list.

TOURNAMENTS

Tournaments need no server and no accounts. Everyone plays the same boards against the same bot, whenever they like before the end date. **Results sync on their own** between everyone in the tournament, and every device checks them move by move.

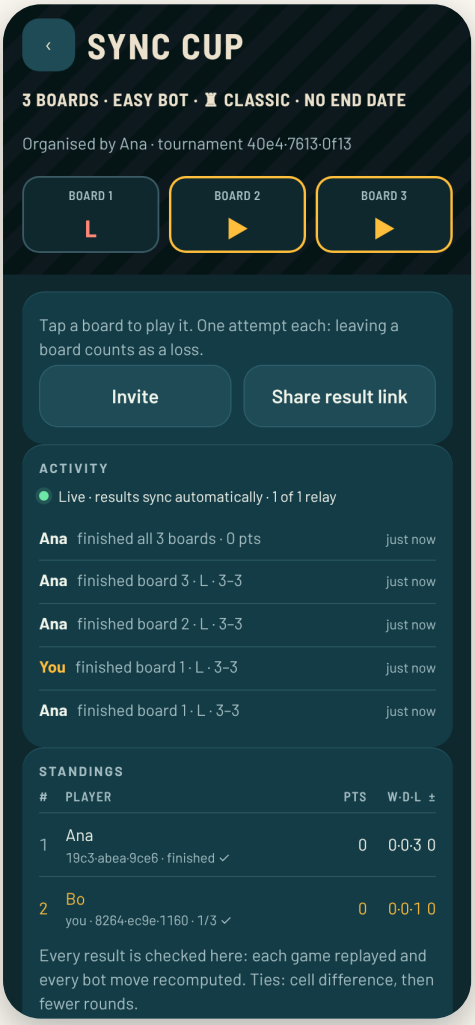
1 CREATE
Name, 3/5/7 boards, bot level, mode, and how long it lasts (1 day to no end).

2 INVITE
Share the invite link in your group. Opening it joins the tournament.

3 PLAY
Tap a board to play it. One attempt each: leaving a board counts as a loss.

4 SYNC
When a board ends, your signed card reaches everyone in the tournament by itself.

5 RANK
Each device checks every card and adds it to the standings. Same cards, same table everywhere.



ACTIVITY

- The tournament screen shows who finished which board, with the result and when it arrived: *Ana · finished board 3 · W · 5 min ago*.
- When someone finishes every board, it says so, with their points.
- A green dot means **Live**: the relays are connected. With the app open you also get a short notice, and *Tournaments* in the home dock shows a red dot until you look.

STANDINGS

- Win 1 point, draw ½.
- Ties: total cell difference at the end of your games, then fewer rounds.
- A player with every board played is marked *finished*.
- *Copy standings* gives a text table for the group chat.

RESULT LINKS STILL WORK
Share result link sends your card by any app, and *Add a result* takes one in. Use them if a friend is on an older version, or on a page that is not https.

TOURNAMENTS: HOW LIVE SYNC WORKS

You finish a board
your device signs your card

→

3 public relays
one encrypted slot per player, kept for whoever opens it later

→

Everyone in the tournament
checks it move by move: Activity and standings update

1

YOUR SLOT

Each player has one slot in the tournament's channel on the same public relays the online rooms use. Your latest card waits there, so whoever opens the tournament later receives it at once — even if you are offline.

2

ENCRYPTED

The channel and the slots are named from the invite code, and every card is encrypted with a key made from it. Without the invite, nobody can find the tournament or read a name or a game.

3

SELF-REPAIRING

Public relays may forget. Every device that opens the tournament puts back any card a relay has lost, so the standings survive as long as anyone in the group opens the app.

WHY IT IS FAIR

- The relays are not trusted: they only carry encrypted cards. Every game in a card is replayed and every bot move recomputed: nobody can claim a result they did not play.
- Each card is signed by its device and must sit in that device's slot; an edited or forged card is rejected. The newest valid card of each player wins.
- The bot plays slightly differently for each device, so copying a friend's winning moves does not work.
- A card is checked once per device and remembered, so opening a tournament stays fast.

GOOD TO KNOW

A card does not prove *when* a board was played, and arrival times depend on when each device was online: play before the end date. With notifications on (page 27) you hear about new results and the last day even with the app closed. Tournament boards are practice for your rating.

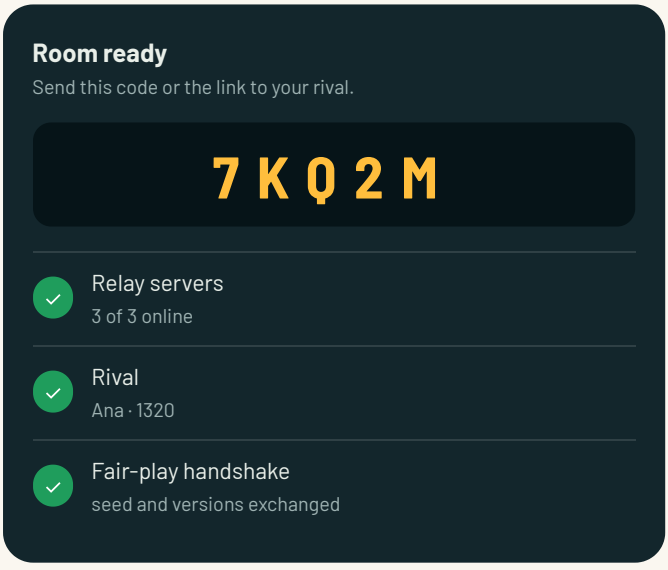
PLAYING ONLINE

START A GAME

1. **Play a friend** in the home dock, then **Create room**: you get a 5-character code and a link. The mode you selected applies.
2. Send it. Your rival taps **Play a friend → Join room** and types the code in the five boxes (or pastes it), or just opens the link.
3. The game starts as soon as both devices meet (with notifications on, you hear when your rival joins). Each round lasts 60 seconds (30 in Blitz); when time runs out, your planned orders are sent.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- Reloaded the page or closed the app? The home screen offers **Rejoin online game** for two hours; the rival's device sends the game back.
- Rival offline for 90 seconds? You can keep waiting or **claim the win**.
- Both devices must run versions with the same protocol; otherwise the handshake says so: update and create a new room.



FAIR PLAY, BUILT IN

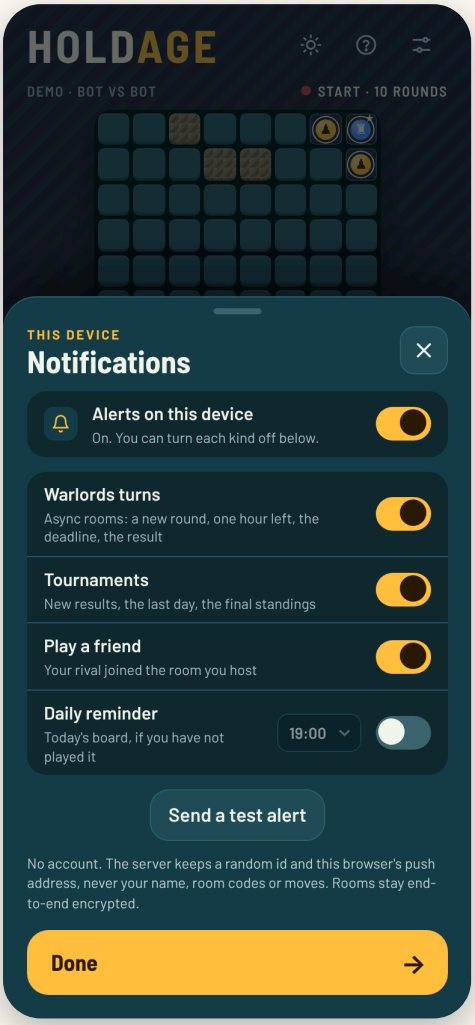
- **No game server**: both devices run the same engine and check each other.
- **Shared board**: the seed is half from each player; nobody chooses it.
- **Sealed orders**: each set travels first as a hash and is revealed only when both have confirmed.
- **Hidden ambushes** are revealed only when they spring, with a proof.
- **Both boards are compared** after every round; any mismatch stops the game.
- **Encrypted relay** over several public servers at once; messages are end-to-end encrypted with the room code.
- At the end, **both devices sign the result** for the rating proof.

ETIQUETTE

Online games are rated (in Classic) with your rival's rating. Resigning or leaving counts as a loss, so finish your games — or claim the win if your rival disappears.

NOTIFICATIONS

HoldAge can tell you when it is your turn, even with the app closed. Alerts are off until you turn them on, on each device, and every kind can be switched off on its own.



TURN THEM ON

1. On the home screen, the sliders → **Notifications** → **Alerts on this device**. The browser asks once: allow.
2. Keep the kinds you want: *Warlords turns*, *Tournaments*, *Play a friend* and the *Daily reminder* with its hour.
3. **Send a test alert** checks that it works.

> **IPHONE AND IPAD**
> Alerts need HoldAge on the Home Screen: *Share* → *Add to Home Screen*, open it from there, then turn alerts on (iOS 16.4 or later).

WHAT YOU HEAR ABOUT

Warlords async rooms	The game starts · a round opens, with its deadline · **one hour left** (only if you have not sealed) · time is up · the result
Tournaments	New results (at most one alert every 3 hours) · the last day · the final standings
Play a friend	Your rival joined the room you host
Daily	Today's board at the hour you chose — not if you already played it

Tap an alert to go straight to the room or tournament. With HoldAge on screen, it shows as a line in the app instead. Live rooms need no alerts: they are played with the app open.

ON THE LOCK SCREEN

HOLDAGE WARLORDS
Room K7Q2M · round 5 is open. Orders due 21:30.

HOLDAGE WARLORDS
Room K7Q2M · round 5: less than an hour to seal your orders.

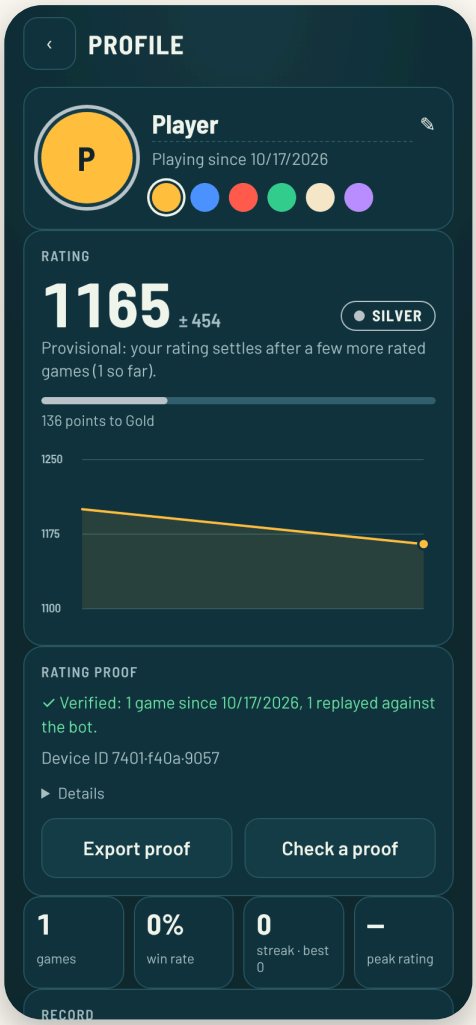
HOLDAGE · TOURNAMENT
New results in "Friday Cup".

> **PRIVATE BY DESIGN**
> No account. The notification server keeps a random device id and your browser's push address — never your name, room codes or moves. Rooms stay end-to-end encrypted on the relays; each alert is encrypted for your device, which adds the room's name from its own memory. Without the server, or offline, the game works exactly the same.

RATING AND RATING PROOF

HoldAge uses **Glicko-2**, the system of major online chess sites. Everyone starts at 1200. Only the result counts (win 1, draw ½, loss 0), not the margin.

- Beating a stronger rival is worth much more than beating a weaker one.
- The ± number is the uncertainty: it shrinks as you play and grows after long breaks. While it is high your rating is provisional and the ± is wide: "1200 ±500" after a first game, "1350 ±120" once it has settled.
- Bots have fixed ratings: Easy 1000, Normal 1550, Hard 1900. Above 1400, 1950 and 2300 respectively, games against them are unrated.
- Unrated: casual modes, daily, named, shared and tournament boards.



TIERS

Bronze	Silver	Gold	Platinum	Diamond	Master	Grandmaster
0+	1100+	1300+	1500+	1700+	1900+	2100+

RATING PROOF

Every result is written on your device into a chain of entries, each signed with your device's key. In your profile, **Export proof** saves it as a file and **Check a proof** verifies anyone's:

BOT GAMES

Replayed move by move: every bot move is recomputed.

ONLINE GAMES

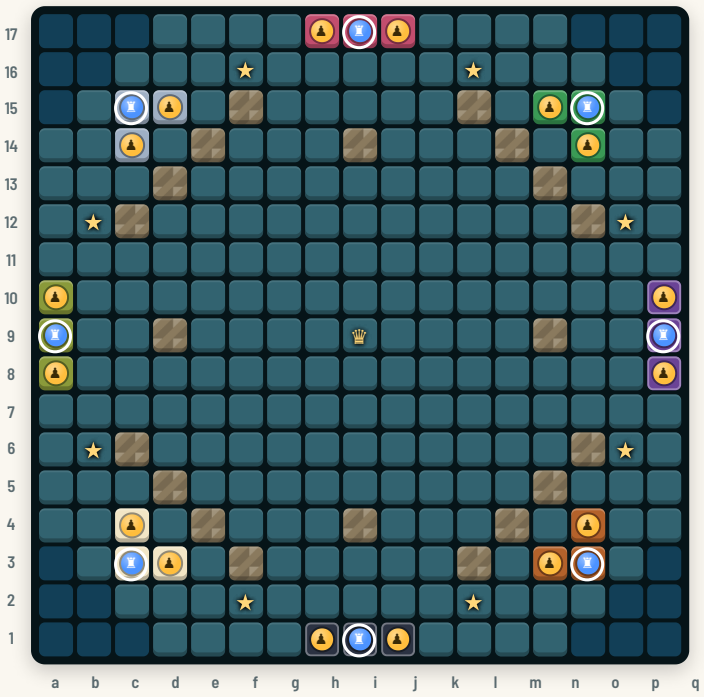
Both devices sign the result; a win needs the rival's signature.

THE RATING

Glicko-2 is applied entry by entry and must give exactly the rating shown.

WARLORDS: EIGHT REALMS

Warlords is HoldAge for up to eight players on a 17×17 map: online with friends — live, or with a deadline for each round — or alone against seven bots. The same orders and the same combat, plus cities, the Crown, and truces you can keep... or break.



The start. Each realm has its capital (ringed) with infantry and two pawns. ★ cities, ♛ the Crown, blue the sea, brown the mountains.

THE REALMS

Four realms start in the corners and four in the middle of each side. All eight start alike: a capital with infantry, two pawns, and a reserve of 4 pawns, 2 infantry, 2 cavalry and 2 archers.

Ivory · Onyx · Clay · Plum · Jade · Rose · Steel · Olive

THE MAP

- ★ **Cities** — eight, one between each pair of neighbouring realms: 3 points each and +1 soldier every round.
- ♛ **The Crown** — in the middle (i9): 5 points, and the key to winning at once.
- **The sea** cuts the four corners. A **mountain** stands in front of each edge realm (i4, i14, d9, n9), so corners and edges are equally far from the Crown.
- **Up to sixteen more mountains** change every game, the same in all eight directions: no realm ever starts better placed.

A GAME IN THREE STEPS

1

PLAN

Give up to 3 orders (4 with 60% or less of the leader's cells). Offer, accept or end truces.

2

REVEAL

Everyone's orders are resolved together by the HoldAge rules. Nothing covers the map: the changed cells flash and each key event lights up in turn while the round fills in the history.

3

GROW

Income as in HoldAge, per realm: pawns for your size and farms, a rotating soldier and one more every 5 cells, barracks, loot — plus +1 soldier for each city you hold.

18 rounds. Rules not mentioned here are those of the classic game: units, combat, mechanics and buildings work exactly the same (pages 6–15).

ON THE PHONE

Pinch to zoom the map and move it with **two fingers**; one finger only taps. Cells you can play are lit (amber frame for free cells, coral with your best a·d for rival cells). Tap one and the same bubble as in the classic game opens: your units on the first row, each with its attack·defense or how many you have in hand; buildings and the bridge on the second row, with their cost. Tap an order again — on the map or in the history — to change or remove it.

THE HISTORY

Under the map, the **strip of rounds** shows the board as it was after any round (*Viewing round 3 · Back to now*). The panel keeps every round, newest first: your orders with what became of them (✓ *taken*, *won* · ✕ *held by*, *contested*), the key events, and *Rivals*, which opens every realm's orders over the panel; the clock at the top opens them too. Tap any line and its cells light up on the map.

WARLORDS: HOW TO WIN

CLAIM THE EMPIRE

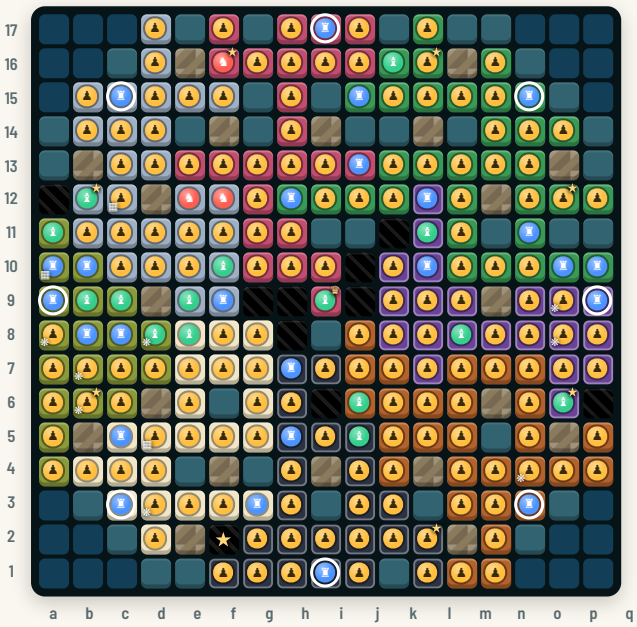
Hold the Crown and at least 1 city at the end of a round: you become the **pretender**, and every realm sees it. Still hold them at the end of the next round and you win at once. One round to stop you: the whole map knows where to strike.

POINTS AFTER ROUND 18

Each cell	1	Each city	3
The Crown	5	Each farm, barracks or wall	2

Plus **glory**: +1 in each round you take land from a realm, +1 in each round you hold back an attack, +5 for a capital. A betrayal costs 2. Ties: more cells, then more glory.

EXAMPLE · A REAL PRETENDER



Game 2 between Normal bots, after round 12: Rose holds the Crown and f16.

Rose ends round 12 on the Crown with f16. The banner turns gold for Rose and red for everyone else: *"If Rose still holds the Crown and a city at the end of this round, it wins."*

- To stop it, take back the Crown **or** every city it holds — one capture is enough.
- Its neighbours are its best answer: they are next to its land and may have a truce to break.
- Hard bots never make peace with a pretender, and strike its Crown and cities first.

NOBODY IS ELIMINATED

A captured capital moves to your largest linked land (+5 glory for the taker). A realm with no land left returns home with infantry as soon as its home cell is free: there is always a way back.

WHICH VICTORY TO AIM FOR

In our balance tests between bots, about a quarter of the games ended with a claim; the rest went to points. A claim usually comes from a realm with peace on both flanks and a march ready toward the centre. On points, cities (3) and buildings (2, safe inside your land) add up faster than they seem.

WARLORDS: TRUCES AND BETRAYAL

TRUCES

- **Offer** a truce to any realm in *Diplomacy*. When both say yes in the same round, it is signed at the reveal.
- From the next round it lasts **5 rounds**: neither side may attack, shoot or lance the other.
- At most **2 truces** at a time.
- **Notice**: either side can end a truce honestly. It still holds for one more round, then ends, at no cost.
- A truce kept to its end, or ended with notice, counts as **kept**.

BETRAYAL

Any attack, shot or lance on a partner is a betrayal. The app warns you before you give the order. At the reveal:

- the truce breaks at once, and every realm sees who broke it;
- the traitor loses **2 points** and cannot sign truces for **4 rounds**;
- the victim gets **+1 attack** against the traitor for **3 rounds**.

Round 5	**Both say yes** — signed at the reveal
Round 6–10	**Truce** — no attacks between them
Round 8	**Notice** — one side ends it honestly
Round 9	**Last round** — the truce still holds
Round 10	**At war** — no cost to anyone

A truce signed in round 5 covers rounds 6 to 10. With notice in round 8, it ends after round 9.

EXAMPLE · THE PRICE OF A CELL



Ivory and Onyx are at peace (rounds 5–9). Ivory orders infantry on g3.

Ivory infantry	4	=	2 base + 2 push
Onyx pawn	2	=	1 base + 1 support

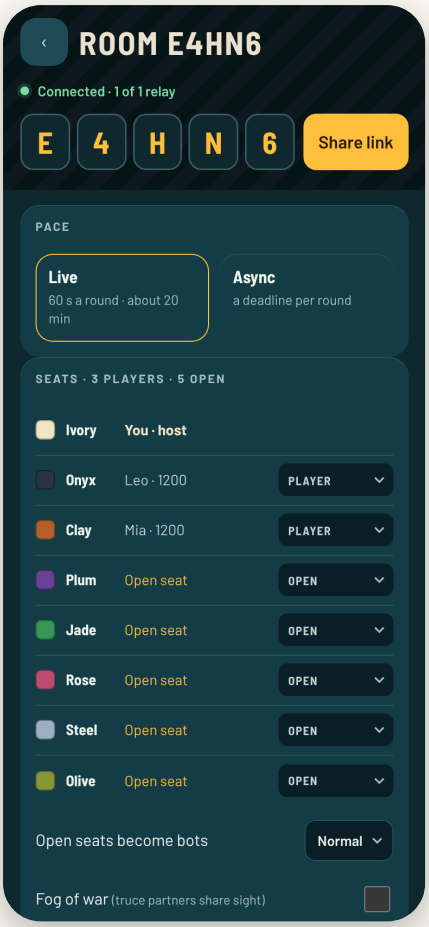
4 > 2 · G3 FALLS — AND THE TRUCE WITH IT

Infantry pushes with the three Ivory cells in a row behind it (+2), while the pawn has one Onyx neighbour for support. The cell falls — but Ivory loses 2 points for the betrayal, cannot sign a truce until round 12, and Onyx attacks it with +1 for 3 rounds. One cell (+1 point, +1 glory) for −2 and a new enemy: betray only for a capital, the Crown or a city — or to stop a pretender.

HONOUR

Your **honour** is the share of truces you kept, over all your rated Warlords games. Every room shows it next to your name: a realm with low honour will find few partners.

WARLORDS ONLINE AND BOTS



A ROOM FOR EIGHT

1. **Create room** in Warlords: you get a 5-character code and a link to share.
2. Friends tap **Join room** and type the code, or open the link. The host seats them; each can ask for a free realm.
3. The host sets the empty seats: open, or a bot (Easy, Normal or Hard). When the game starts, open seats become bots.
4. Choose the **pace**: **Live** (60 seconds a round) or **Async** (a deadline of 2, 8 or 24 hours a round). Fog of war is optional; truce partners share their sight.

SEALED ORDERS, NO GAME SERVER

- Like a classic online game, every device runs the same engine: the rooms travel over public relays, encrypted with the room code, and every message is signed by its device.
- **Live**: orders travel first as a hash and are revealed when everyone has sealed. If the game is open at the deadline, your planned orders are sealed for you.
- **Async**: orders travel at once, encrypted for the room; the app opens them only at the reveal. The round resolves as soon as everyone has sealed — or at the deadline.
- Bots' moves are drawn from all the sealed orders, so nobody can work them out in advance.

DO NOT MISS A TURN

Turn on **notifications** (page 27): HoldAge tells you when a round opens and **an hour before the deadline** if you have not sealed, even with the app closed. The game menu can also add the deadline to your calendar. Miss a deadline and a bot plays that round for you, keeping your truces; miss two in a row and it keeps your realm until you come back — you play again from the next round.

RATING AND HONOUR

Warlords has its own **rating** (Glicko-2, separate from the classic one). Each game counts your final place against every other realm, weighted so one game moves it about as much as a classic game. Bots count with fixed ratings — Easy 1000, Normal 1550, Hard 1900 — up to a ceiling 400 above.

THE BOTS

EASY

Gives one order fewer and plays loosely: a good table to learn on.

NORMAL

The classic heuristics: free cells, marches, the right unit, cuts, farms and walls.

HARD

Checks several plans one round ahead against what the others will likely do; builds, defends and goes for pretenders.

Each bot also has a hidden personality: some conquer, some build, some guard their land — and one kind schemes, and may break a truce for a big prize.

WARLORDS: STRATEGY

1 PEACE ON ONE FRONT

You can fight one neighbour, not two. Offer a truce to the one you border least and spend your orders on the other.

2 CITIES FEED ARMIES

Each city gives 3 points and a soldier every round. The two cities beside your capital are your first targets — and your neighbours'.

3 BUILD INSIDE

Farms, barracks and walls are worth 2 points each. Build on cells with your own land all around; on the border they fall with the cell.

4 NEVER LET A PRETENDER STAND

When a realm takes the crown, everyone has one round. Break a truce if you must: losing the game costs more than two points.

5 TIME YOUR TRUCES

A truce lasts 5 rounds. Sign it when you need your orders elsewhere; let it end — or give notice — when your neighbour is busy on its other side.

6 BEHIND? USE THE FOURTH ORDER

With 60% or less of the leader's cells you get 4 orders: enough for a march and a lance into a neck.

BEFORE YOU SEAL

1. Who is the leader, and who is the pretender?
2. Which of my borders is at peace, and for how long?
3. Are my cities and my capital's neighbours guarded with the right unit?
4. Does any order break a truce? (The app marks it red.)
5. Did I answer every truce offer?
6. Do my marches cross cells a neighbour may also take?
7. Async: is the deadline in my calendar?
8. Live: are all my orders in before the timer ends?

READING THE TABLE

Tap any realm in the strip under the map to see its points, cells, cities, reserve and truces. A flag ⚑ marks your partners; a crown ♛ the pretender.

STRATEGY GUIDE: PRINCIPLES

1 SHAPE BEFORE SIZE

A compact blob defends itself (support, phalanx) and cannot be cut. A long snake is a gift. Fill diagonals and gaps before reaching further.

2 COUNT BEFORE YOU ATTACK

Attack only when you win even if the rival changes the garrison to their best answer — or when losing the attack costs you nothing important.

3 HIT NECKS

One capture that disconnects four cells is worth five captures elsewhere. Look for the thinnest point between the rival's front and capital.

4 DEFEND WHAT THEY NEED

The rival wants your necks too. Change their garrisons to the unit that beats what can reach them, or wall them.

5 PAWNS ARE TEMPO

You get at least 3 pawns every round. Spend them every round: expanding, marching, building. Unused pawns over the cap of 6 are lost.

6 READ THE ROTATION

Both players receive the same soldier type from their capital each round. If cavalry arrives next round for both, infantry garrisons become valuable.

7 VARY YOUR PLAY

Simultaneous orders punish predictability. If you always attack the same cell, the rival will meet you there with the right unit.

8 KNOW THE CLOCK

From round 10, a 10-cell lead ends the game. In the last rounds, a cheap farm is a point. At round 20, only points matter.

THE THREE PHASES

OPENING · ROUNDS 1–5

- Pawns to free cells, compact shape.
- A farm on an inner cell by round 3–4.
- Keep 2–3 soldiers in reserve for the first contact.

MIDDLE · ROUNDS 6–14

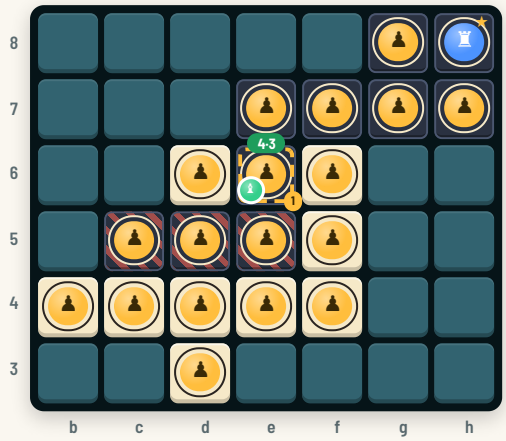
- Fight on the border: right unit, flank, push.
- Look for cuts every round; protect your necks.
- Barracks behind the front; walls on necks.

END · ROUNDS 15–20

- Count points every round: cells + buildings.
- Ahead: defend, build cheap farms for points.
- Behind: use Reaction's 4th order on cuts.

STRATEGY CASES (1)

Case 1 THE NECK CUT



One order, four cells.

Situation. The rival pushed a line down to c5. It looks threatening, but it hangs on a single cell, e6.
Plan. Attack e6 with the unit that wins there: archers get +1 strike and +1 flank from your two cells beside it, 4 vs 3.
Result. e6 falls and c5, d5, e5 are cut off: the rival loses 4 cells, you gain 1 — a swing of 5 with a single order.

> **TAKEAWAY**
> Before attacking the tip of a rival advance, look at its root.

Case 2 GUESSING RIGHT IN SIMULTANEOUS PLAY

Your infantry holds d4 (defense 4 with support). The rival can reach it with archers (5, wins) or cavalry (2, loses). You can keep the infantry, or change the garrison to cavalry (which beats archers). What happens in each case?

	RIVAL SENDS ARCHERS	RIVAL SENDS CAVALRY	RIVAL DOES NOT ATTACK
You keep infantry	**d4 falls** (5-4)	**holds easily** (2-6)	nothing spent
You switch to cavalry	**holds** (3-5: cavalry beats archers)	**holds** (same unit: the attack fails)	one order used; infantry back in reserve

> **TAKEAWAY**
> Switching the garrison covers both attacks at the cost of one order. Do it on cells that matter (necks, capital neighbours); elsewhere, spend the order on your own attack.

Case 3 THE CAPITAL SQUEEZE



The capital's two neighbours are now yours.

With both neighbours still the rival's, the same archers only reached 5 vs 6 (page 16). Take g8 and h7 first: the capital loses its support and your cells add flank.

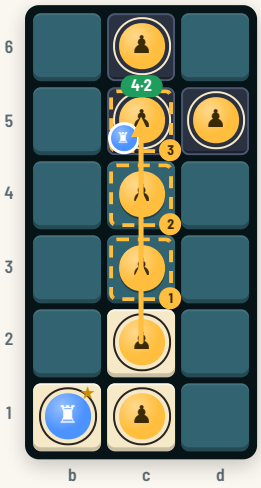
Archers	6	=	2 base + 2 advantage + 1 strike + 1 flank
★ Capital	5	=	2 base + 1 hold + 2 capital

6 > 5 · THE ATTACK WINS

Cavalry would still fail (3 vs 7): infantry beats it. The capital starts with infantry — bring archers.

STRATEGY CASES (2)

Case 4 LANCE THROUGH OPEN GROUND



Three orders: two pawns and an infantry tip.

Situation. A gap of free cells separates you from a rival pawn line. A plain attack is out of reach — and even adjacent it would tie 2–2.

Plan. March two pawns and finish with infantry: +2 lance, 4 vs 2.

Risk. If the rival sends a pawn to c3 or c4 too, that link burns and the tip is cut off. Do it when the rival has few pawns, or when the reward (a neck) is worth the gamble.

Case 5 THE ECONOMY RACE

PLAN	ROUNDS 1–4	BY ROUND 10	BY ROUND 20
No buildings	2 pawns kept: 2 more cells	—	—
Farm on round 3	2 pawns spent	+7 pawns	+17 pawns and 1 point
Barracks (cavalry) on round 5	—	+5 cavalry	+15 cavalry and 1 point

TAKEAWAY

An early farm pays for itself in two rounds and keeps giving all game. But a building on the border can be lost the round it is built (the pawns come back) or soon after (they do not). Build inside, expand outside.

Case 6 CLOSING OUT A WON GAME

You lead by 8 cells at round 12. The rival trails by 6 or more, so they get a **4th order** every round. Do not chase the last two cells of the lead victory with risky marches: change garrisons on your necks, wall the one closest to their front, and take free cells with pawns. The rival must attack into your strength: every failed attack costs them units and an order, while your pawns keep widening the gap toward 10.

STRATEGY: AGAINST THE BOT AND CHECKLISTS

BEATING THE BOT

- The bot never sees your orders: it plays blind, like you.
- **Hard** asks the Normal planner for several plans, plays each one round ahead against your likely answer and keeps the best. Vary your attacks: it expects the obvious one.
- **Easy** plays half its rounds at random; punish loose cells and expand fast.
- **Normal** loves marches and lances toward your capital and attacks cells it can cut. Keep your capital area compact and garrison its neighbours with infantry.
- It sets ambushes near the border about a third of the time: a lone pawn into a quiet free cell next to its territory may be a trap. Probe with pawns, not soldiers.
- It values walls near its capital and barracks inside. Archers alone only tie a walled pawn (3–3): add flank to break it. Shots remove barracks garrisons.

BEFORE YOU CONFIRM

1. Did I use all my orders? (A pass is rarely right.)
2. Can any of my necks fall? (Turn on ⚠.)
3. Does each attack still win if they change the garrison?
4. Is there a cut worth more than my best capture?
5. Will my pawns exceed the cap of 6 next round?
6. What soldier arrives next round, for both of us?

COMMON MISTAKES

- Attacking with the wrong unit (check the triangle first).
- Long marches into contested ground.
- Buildings on the front line.
- Forgetting that ties go to the defender.
- Sending a pawn where the rival also sends a pawn — burned cell.

STRATEGY BY MODE

♜ CLASSIC

Farm early, fight on the border from round 5, count points from 15.

⚡ BLITZ

Skip farms. Use the big reserve at once; aim for the lead victory from round 6.

▒ FOG

Advance to see. Attack cells you can see; raid hidden ones with cavalry.

▲ HILL

March pawns to the centre by round 4, then garrison it with infantry.

QUICK REFERENCE

UNITS

	STR.	BEATS	BONUS
Pawn	1	—	marches, pays
Infantry	2		+1 defending; push
Cavalry	2		reach 2; charge
Archers	2		+1 attacking; shot

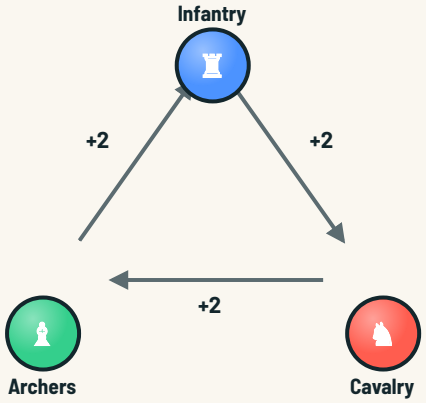
ATTACK

base + advantage 2 + strike 1 + flank ≤2 + charge 1 + push ≤2 + lance ≤2 (out of reach only)

DEFENSE

base + advantage 2 + hold 1 + wall 2 + capital 2 + support ≤2 + phalanx 1

Attack must be greater than defense. Ties: the defender holds.



BUILDINGS

	COST	EFFECT
❋ Farm	2	+1 pawn / round
⚑ Barracks	3	+1 garrison unit / round
▦ Wall	3	+2 defense
≡ Bridge	2	black cell → yours

INCOME PER ROUND

pawns: max(3, cells ÷ 3) + farms · soldiers: capital 1 + cells ÷ 5 (rotating) + barracks · loot 1 · cap 6 per type

ORDERS

3 per round, 4 if 6+ cells behind · one per cell · ambush: 1 pawn, 5 rounds, one at a time · shot: archers, 2 cells in a line, not the capital

VICTORY

capital · 65% of playable cells · from round 10, +10 cells · round 20: cells + buildings

MODES

Blitz 12 rounds · Fog: sight 2 · Hill: 3 of 4 centre cells for 3 rounds · Warlords: 8 realms, 18 rounds, Crown + a city twice in a row

HOME SCREEN

tap: pause · swipe: browse rounds · press and hold HOLD: continue or play

GLOSSARY

Coloured tokens are the bonus names exactly as they appear in the attack·defense cards of this guide (for example **2 advantage**).

a·d	Attack · defense of an order, written with a middle dot (5·3). Shown on the pills in the diagrams and in the game's bubble.	p. 7
advantage	+2 when a unit beats the other in the triangle (infantry → cavalry → archers → infantry). Works in attack and defense.	p. 6
Ambush	A hidden trap for 1 pawn on a free cell next to you, for 5 rounds. A rival unit placed there is lost.	p. 12
base	The unit's strength: pawn 1, soldiers 2. The first token of every attack·defense sum.	p. 7
Black cell	A free cell where both players sent the same unit; nobody can hold it until a bridge.	p. 9
Bounce	Two different units with equal attack on a free cell: nobody takes it and both are spent.	p. 9
capital	+2 defense on the capital ★. Taking the rival capital wins the game.	p. 16
Card	A signed tournament result. It syncs to everyone in the tournament on its own, or travels as a link.	p. 24
charge	+1 for cavalry with a run-up: an own cell two steps away, the cell between free.	p. 11
Cut / supply	Cells not connected to their capital are lost at the end of the round.	p. 13
flank	+1 per own cell touching the target beyond the first (max +2). In clashes on free cells it counts too.	p. 11
Garrison	The unit on a cell. Placing a unit on your own cell replaces it; the old one returns to reserve.	p. 5
hold	+1 for infantry when defending.	p. 6
HOLD	The home-screen button: press and hold to continue your game or start one.	p. 17
Honour	In Warlords, the share of truces you kept over all your rated games; every room shows it.	p. 31
lance	A march that ends in an attack out of normal reach: +1 per link, max +2.	p. 10
Link / march	An order that continues in a straight line from another order on a free cell; each step is a link.	p. 10
Neck	A cell whose loss disconnects other cells.	p. 13
phalanx	+1 defense for a cell in a line of 3 or more with at most two own neighbours.	p. 11
Pill	The small label on a diagram cell with a·d: green when the attack wins, red when it falls short, grey for a bounce.	p. 7
Practice	A game that never changes the rating (daily, named, shared, tournament boards).	p. 22
Pretender	In Warlords, the realm that ends a round on the Crown with a city. One more round like that wins.	p. 30
push	+1 for infantry per own cell in a row behind the attack, from the second (max +2).	p. 11
Reach	Cells next to your territory (2 for cavalry), extended by marches.	p. 5
Reserve	The units in your hand, shown in your player row.	p. 15
Seed	The value that fixes the board. Same seed, same board.	p. 22
Shot ➹	Archers remove a rival piece 2 cells away in a straight line without occupying the cell.	p. 12
strike	+1 for archers when attacking (shots included).	p. 6
support	+1 defense per own neighbour of the cell beyond the first (max +2).	p. 11
Swing	Cells you gain plus cells the rival loses in a round.	p. 23
Tie	Attack equal to defense: the defender holds.	p. 7
Tier	Your rating band, from Bronze to Grandmaster.	p. 28
Truce	In Warlords, five rounds without attacks between two realms. Notice ends it after one round; an attack breaks it.	p. 31
wall	+2 defense from a wall building on the cell.	p. 14

HoldAge is made by MPe Software. Have fun, and hold the board.